

Original

Kalila: Ynez? Oh my God! It's been... how long? Ten years? More?

Ynez: Yeah... Something like that.

Kalila: I almost didn't recognize you. You always kept your hair down back then. Now, you're a grown woman. How have you been?

Ynez: I've been... okay. I guess?

Kalila: It's so strange running into you here, especially now, with all this happening. How long have you been in the city?

Ynez: Um... A few months. Things aren't that great back home, so.

Kalila: Ugh, yeah, I can imagine. Safer here. I mean, as safe as anywhere can be these days. Are you staying with your aunt like you used to in the summers?

Ynez: No. No, she uh... she— she died last year.

Kalila: Oh... wow. She was a kind woman. Always made sure I had everything I needed when I babysat you. I'm so sorry for your losses. Your parents, your aunt... that's a lot for a girl your age. So, I guess staying here is for the best, right? Safer than your country, y'know with all those... well you know.

Ynez: ... Yeah. I do.

Kalila: I mean... it's not exactly peaceful here either, especially after what's happened. But at least we don't have those people from your country running around causing chaos. That bombing this morning is just unforgivable. I don't know how they can keep doing this.

Ynez: MY country didn't bomb anyone today.

Kalila: Oh, come on, Ynez. Don't be naïve. We wouldn't have retaliated if your people hadn't attacked us first. This is their fault, and you should just be grateful that you are able to be here and away from those criminals.

Ynez: Criminals? Is that what you think of us? I'm here because your country won't leave mine alone. We're not criminals. We are fighting for our lives.

Kalila: Fighting for your lives? How? By killing innocent people? Some defense, Ynez. How many times do you think we can be hit before hitting back? Actions have consequences.

Ynez: YOU attacked us first. YOU! Your side is just louder... more globally accepted. Ha, but I guess the favorable side always gets to decide who is right and who is wrong.

Kalila: That's ridiculous. We're defending ourselves. You know, I can't even believe you would defend them after all they've done.

Ynez: They who? Who are they? Give me a name.

Kalila: ...

Ynez: Exactly. We are just people. No groups. No organization. Individuals with lives and loved ones, just like you. My life is not less important than yours.

Kalila: I didn't say that Ynez.

Ynez: No? You only talk about us like we're terrorists.

Kalila: Not you, them.

Ynez: ... You just don't get it. And you won't. Because you don't have to. How's your life? Husband? Kids? White picket fence? Everything you used to say you wanted.

Kalila: Well maybe if your leaders stopped trying to attack us, you could have that life too.

Ynez: Well maybe if your leaders stopped treating my country like a terrorist hub and decimating entire counties, I already would've. But that's never going to happen, is it? Not when you all think we're the enemy.

Kalila: Because your side IS the enemy. How else do you explain the constant attacks? It's practically endless.

Ynez: How many attacks have been on your soil compared to ours? Around 1 in 100, maybe.

Kalila: Ynez...

Ynez: It's endless because no one wants to listen. Everyone just wants to blame us and act like they're the victims when you have been attacking us my entire life. I'm not saying we're the picture of innocence, but we're not the only ones with blood on our hands.

Kalila: Ynez... This is pointless. We will never see eye to eye on this.

Ynez: No, we won't.

Kalila: I just... I don't know what else to say. It's disappointing to see you have ended up on the wrong side of this.

Ynez: The wrong side? We barely have a side. In my country, every breath is another fight for survival.

Kalila: Maybe so... But at least I'm surviving on the right side. You should consider yourself lucky for the chance to be here.

Ynez: You aren't surviving though, you're living. Your life isn't being endangered. You literally could have anything you want!

Kalila: You know what? Let's just leave it. We're circling each other.

Ynez: My train is almost here anyways.

Kalila: ...

Ynez: Be safe, okay?

Kalila: Is that some kind of threat?

Ynez: No, Kalila. I just want you to stay safe.

Revised

Kalila: Ynez? Oh my God! It's been... how long? Ten years? More?

Ynez: Yeah... Something like that.

Kalila: I almost didn't recognize you. You always kept your hair down back then. Now, you're a grown woman. How have you been?

Ynez: I've been... okay. I guess.

Kalila: It's so strange running into you here, especially now, with all this happening. How long have you been in the city?

Ynez: Um... A few months. Things aren't that great back home, so...

Kalila: Ugh, yeah, I can imagine. Safer here. I mean, as safe as anywhere can be these days. Are you staying with your aunt like you used to in the summers?

Ynez: No. No, she uh... she— she passed away last year.

Kalila: Oh... wow. I'm sorry, Ynez. She was a kind woman. Always made sure I had everything I needed when I babysat you. First your parents, now your aunt... that's a lot for a girl your age. So, I guess staying here is for the best, right? Safer than your country, y'know with all those... well you know.

Ynez: ... No, Kalila, I don't. What do you mean, exactly?

Kalila: Y'know... I mean, c'mon... it's not exactly peaceful here either, especially after what's happened. But at least we don't have those people from your country running around causing mayhem. That bombing this morning is just unforgiveable. I don't know how they can keep doing this.

Ynez: MY country didn't bomb anyone today!

Kalila: Oh, come on, Ynez. Don't be naïve. We wouldn't have retaliated if your people hadn't attacked us first. This is their fault, and you should just be grateful that you're able to be here and away from those criminals.

Ynez: Criminals? Is that what you think of us? I'm here because your country won't leave mine alone. We're not criminals, Kalila. We're fighting for our lives.

Kalila: Fighting for your lives? How? By killing innocent people? Some defense, Ynez. How many times do you think we can be hit before hitting back? Actions have consequences.

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Kalila: ...

Ynez: Exactly. We are just people. No groups. No organization. Individuals. Just individuals with lives and loved ones, just like you. My life is not worth less than yours.

Kalila: I didn't say that Ynez.

Ynez: No? You only talk about us like we're terrorists.

Kalila: Not you. Them.

Ynez: ... You just don't get it. And you won't. Because you don't have to. You're too removed from it. How's your life? Husband? Kids? White picket fence? Everything you used to say you wanted.

Kalila: Well maybe if your leaders stopped trying to attack us, you could have that life too.

Ynez: Well maybe if your leaders stopped turning my country into a warzone, I already would've. But that's never going to happen, is it? Not when you all think we're the enemy.

Kalila: Because your side IS the enemy. How else do you explain the constant attacks? It's practically endless.

Ynez: How many attacks have been on your soil compared to ours? Around 1 in 100, maybe.

Kalila: Ynez...

Ynez: It's endless because no one wants to listen. Everyone just wants to blame us and act like they're the victims when you have been attacking us my entire life. I'm not saying we're the picture of innocence, but we're not the only ones with blood on our hands.

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Kalila: Maybe so... But at least I'm surviving on the right side. You're lucky to be here.

Ynez: You aren't surviving though, you're living. I told you. You're too far removed from it all. Your life isn't being endangered. You literally could have anything you want!

Kalila: You know what? Let's just leave it. We're going in circles.

Ynez: My train is almost here anyways.

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Ynez: Stay safe, okay?

Kalila: Is that some kind of threat?

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Reflective Writing

One change I made while reading over it, was to make the dialogue seem more natural. I did this by removing or changing certain words in certain sentences. An example of this is changing "we are" to "we're." While these have the same meaning, I am used to hearing people contract words from their full form. I also followed your advice to make Ynez respond to Kalila talking about her country being a safer place for Ynez. I did this by changing Ynez's line that says "... Yeah. I do" to ... "No, Kalila, I don't. What do you mean, exactly?" I made this change because I believe it felt more in character for Ynez to not feel safe in either of their countries because of the conflict. I think this change impacts the work by showing that Ynez is willing to stand up for

herself and her country when Kalila is initially trash talking it. One thing I chose not to address is naming and giving a reasoning behind the group Kalila and Ynez are discussing. I chose not to address this because I don't want to describe a group that has any similarities to real-life groups. I would rather it be a nameless group without any description, so that readers can decide what they have done and whether they agree with Kalila or Ynez. I find this concept to be interesting as it can reveal personal biases towards the oppressed, the oppressors, and those who try and fight for either side. Another thing I chose not to address was a recommendation from a classmate to add stuttering for emotional effect. I chose not to add this because I wanted both women to feel confident in their beliefs, even if they cannot defend them.

The message in our textbook that stuck with me most was where it says, "creating believable characters" (pp. 493, 540-551). This part stuck with me because I have always felt that characters are the most important part of a story. I believe that the plot of a story could be amazing, but if the characters are not entertaining, I cannot continue watching or reading. The example in the textbook that helped me most was "Sure Thing" by David Ives. The reason this piece helped me has less to do with the writing itself, and more to do with the structure. When starting my piece, I was confused on how the dialogue was meant to look just based off the instructions, so this piece helped me to understand it more. I think my work easily contrasts this piece as my work features two women in an argument while Ives piece features a man and a woman getting to know each other. The biggest challenge I faced was trying to keep it under five pages. As I was writing, I felt like I could've continued past the recommended pages, so I had to find a way to bring the conversation to an end. I think my biggest success with this piece was creating a realistic conflict between the characters, as war and terrorism are major world issues that leave families and friends divided. This is a genre that I previously tried to write in a few years back (around 2020), but I gave up because I did not have experience. Now, I could see myself trying to write in this genre again. For this piece, I doubt I will return to it, at least any time soon. Although, I may revisit the characters for our short story assignment. I know that two of the topics chooses (unsympathetic character and traumatic event) could relate to these characters, but it mostly depends on if I can think of a story to tell when the time comes.